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LEADING THE WAY
PM Modi with world leaders at the Gandhi Memorial at Raj Ghat, Sept. 10

and regulated approach towards dealing with cryptocurrency (see graphic *India G20: The Big Breakthroughs*). The Indian G20 resulted in 73 action-oriented outcomes, double the number under the Indonesian presidency in 2022 or the Italian helmsmanship the year before. "Prime Minister Modi was clear that India's G20 presidency should result in actionable outcomes and that India should leave a lasting legacy, particularly for the development of the Global South," says Dr Pramod K. Mishra, principal secretary to the prime minister.

Led by the PMO, review meetings have been called for all the respective ministries involved in dealing with the outcomes. The prime minister has also called for a virtual summit of G20 leaders in November to review the progress made before India hands over the presidency to Brazil for 2024. That will be the toughest part. The G20 functions more like a club of nations than an executive organisation. It is a normative body with probably the biggest achievement coming only way back in 2008 when it moved to sort out the global financial meltdown caused by the collapse of the Lehman Brothers. It was around this time that it was elevated from a financial ministers' meet to the heads of government level to make it more decisive. Earlier G20 meetings were dominated by the agenda set by the G7 grouping of powerful nations. But India during its presidency, along with other emerging nations such as Brazil, South Africa and Indonesia, worked in tandem to give the G20 a development agenda that reflected the aspirations of the Global South.

Syed Akbaruddin, India's former permanent representative to the UN, says, "If the Western countries led by the US agreed to a less aggressive formulation of the Ukraine war than that of Bali by not naming and shaming Russia directly, it was because they realised they would undermine India's stature if there was no Delhi Declaration. Also, it could end up giving the upper hand to China, which had expanded the BRICS and SCO grouping to counter the West. So, the Western nations found a technical fix to the language in the declaration and decided they would live to fight another day or in another forum." Akbaruddin points out that the G20 is not structured to be an implementation body and India would have to travel considerable distance to have the agenda set in New Delhi put into action.

Expectedly, Ukraine expressed its deep disappointment with what it perceived as Russia having its way and the West capitulating to Indian pressure to reach a consensus. British prime minister Rishi Sunak faced criticism from Opposition MPs for allowing a "weakened" statement on Ukraine as did some other Western leaders when they returned home. French president Emmanuel Macron defensively pointed out that the G20 was not primarily meant to sort out geopolitical issues. Many experts said that the G20 has dropped several notches in status by downplaying geopolitical issues. John Bolton, a former US national security adviser, called for G20 to be disbanded altogether. Writing in the *Washington Post*, Bolton argued, "Mountains of final communiques, joint statements and outcome documents have contributed to global deforestation and nothing else." Bolton cryptically observed that the Delhi Declaration contained only "an anodyne comment on Russia's unprovoked aggression, even weaker than its 2022 (Bali) statement".



"THE G20 HAS CONTRIBUTED TO MAKING INDIA WORLD-READY AND THE WORLD INDIA-READY"

S. JAISHANKAR
Union Minister for External Affairs

Kant denies the charge and asserts that the New Delhi Declaration was a hard-fought consensus that not only reiterated what Bali said but was much stronger with a clear message to Russia and other countries to not transgress on territorial sovereignty. Kant says, "What we achieved is moderating the geopolitical voice. We cooled down temperatures and pushed for a diplomatic settlement to the Ukraine War." A host of foreign policy experts agree that India's G20 presidency was an unqualified success. Not only because of the